I Compared My Kid to Other Kids. I Had to Stop

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It happened at the playground behind our building. My daughter was three and a half, sitting in the sandbox eating sand like it was a job, while a boy maybe six months younger than her counted to fifty on the swings. Fifty. His mom smiled at me, the proud tired smile, and said “he just picked it up!”

I smiled back. Then I went home and googled “3 year old can’t count to 20 normal” at 11:40pm while my husband slept next to me. That’s the part I’m least proud of. Not the comparing — the midnight search history.

The comparison trap has a specific flavor. It’s never about the big stuff. It’s always small and stupid: someone else’s kid says “actually” correctly in a sentence. Someone else’s kid pedals a bike. Someone else’s two-year-old says “thank you” unprompted and mine just screamed “MINE” at a pigeon.

I tried to logic my way out of it. I made a list in my head of things my daughter could do that other kids couldn’t — she could name every dinosaur, she was kind to the cat, she had an incredible memory for song lyrics. It helped for about ten minutes. Then we’d go back to the playground and some kid would do long division or whatever and I’d be right back in it.

What flopped hardest was the “she’ll catch up” pep talk I gave myself. Because sometimes the fear isn’t really about counting. It’s about me. Am I doing enough? Did I miss a window? Should she be in some class? The comparing was never about her at all — it was my own anxiety wearing her face.

What I tell myself now, when I feel it starting, is this: she’s not behind. She’s just on her own weird schedule, like every kid I’ve ever actually known up close. The boy from the swings? Six months later he was terrified of the slide and my daughter was flying down it headfirst. Kids are lopsided. They always are.

I also muted the neighborhood parents' group chat for a month. That chat is 90% "my son just—" and "my daughter already—" and it was feeding the spiral on purpose, like leaving a tap running. The month I muted it, I compared less. Correlation, causation, whatever — my evenings got quieter and so did my head. I unmuted it eventually, for the lost-jacket alerts, but I scroll past the milestone posts now. I know what they do to me.

I still catch myself doing it. Last week at the library, a girl her age was reading actual words off a page and my stomach dropped. But now I notice the drop, name it — "that's the spiral, not a fact" — and let it pass. It passes faster than it used to.

She counted to twenty last month, by the way. On the toilet. Naked. Screaming it like a victory chant. It was perfect.